

Catalyst Works: Discovery & Working Transcript (v3)

The full path that produced the v2 verdict, not just the conclusion. Version 1 of this transcript flagged the questions only the owner could answer and gave a best hypothesis for each. He has now answered them. This version replaces every hypothesis with his actual position, drives the five-whys chain to the owner-confirmed root, and re-runs the Council against the one fact that changed everything: the commitment is made. Companion to the [Margin Diagnostic Sprint report \(v2\)](#).

Prepared 2026-06-26 (v3) · Confidential / internal · The owner-input questions in v1 are now answered from his live discovery; answers shown in green.

WHAT CHANGED IN V2, AND WHAT V3 ADDS

Version 1 ran the discovery on the evidence alone and honestly flagged four questions as owner-input-needed: commitment, goal, risk tolerance, and the "why." The owner answered all of them, plus delivery model, distribution reality, proof, and budget. The headline answer rewrites the diagnosis: he is all in, full-time, boats burned. So the binding constraint is no longer "will he commit." It drops one level, to the moment he is in front of a buyer and loses the room. This transcript shows that whole correction, step by step. Version 3 carries the same path forward and adds, in the companion report, a dollar-sized cost of that lost room (about \$12k a month not switched on); the diagnosis here is unchanged.

A Opening: Inciting Incident & the Corrected Mixed Signal

The discovery call opens by listening for the inciting incident and the mixed signals. In v2, the owner's answers sharpen the mixed signal into something the documents alone could not show.

Q. What made you decide to look at this now? What is the inciting incident?

A. Roughly ten weeks of full build with zero consistent revenue, capped by a flagship paid workshop that sold zero seats against 350 ad clicks. But the deeper trigger is a decision: he job-searched February to May, got no traction, and committed fully to Catalyst Works. Now that it is the only boat, the question "why is it not working" became urgent and personal.

Q. Walk me through the current state in one breath.

A. A complete business on paper: brand, a four-rung offer ladder, six-plus live Stripe links, a Calendly with qualifiers, five landing pages, a 1,846-line audit tool, lead magnets, playbooks, and a researched strategy. Stage, per the company's own Notion hub: "\$0 to first contract." No closed paying client in any source. And the owner is now all in, full-time, unlimited hours.

Q. Where do the signals not add up? What is the mixed signal?

A. This is where v2 sees what v1 could not. The owner converts in person ("when they work with me, things go really well") but is not in the rooms, and when he is in front of someone, about 70 percent leave not knowing what he does. So the mixed signal is: strong closer, zero closes. The capability is there, the commitment is there, and the revenue is still zero, because the first conversation leaks at clarity and then at the ask. The gap is two feet of conversation, not capability and not direction.

B Live Maturity Scoring (4-Level Model, re-scored)

Catalyst Works scores a client live on a four-level maturity model. Here it re-scores its own revenue engine on the owner's answers. The row that moved most: Founder Commitment, Level 1 to Level 4.

Q. Is the owner committed to this as the primary business?

SCORES L4 (WAS L1)

A. Yes, fully. Job-searched Feb to May, no traction, burned the boats. Full-time, unlimited hours. The v1 binding precondition is closed.

Q. Is there a written strategy with a defined buyer and a research base?

SCORES L3

A. Yes, and it is strong. Precise ICP, outcome-first positioning, clean ladder, discovery system, real research base. Operationalized on paper.

Q. Is there a repeatable system that puts him in front of qualified buyers?

SCORES L1

A. No. Not in BNI, Chamber, or owner rooms. Four months of online prospecting failed. Distribution is Level 1.

Q. Is there a rail that carries the first conversation from "what I do" to the ask?

SCORES L1

A. No, and this is the decisive new score. He has no locked offer, so he improvises, rambles, and never reaches the ask. ~70% leave not knowing what he does. In-room clarity and ask is Level 1.

Q. Is there any client proof or credibility asset?

SCORES L1

A. No client logos. Operator-as-proof (running his own business on AI agents) exists but is unpackaged. Level 1, but readily fixable.

Q. Does he convert once he is actually working with someone?

SCORES L3

A. Yes. "When they work with me, things go really well." Delivery and conversion-in-engagement are strong. The leak is strictly upstream, at the first conversation.

LIVE SCORE READ-BACK (V2)

Founder Commitment now Level 4. Strategy Level 3. Built assets overbuilt at Level 4. The new floor is a pair at Level 1: distribution (not in the rooms) and the in-room clarity-and-ask rail (no rail). A business sells from its lowest score. With commitment fixed, the binding score is the rail, because rooms without a rail leak and a confused prospect cannot refer.

C The 8-Lens Diagnostic (re-run on the owner answers)

One diagnostic question per lens, re-answered with the owner's live input. The governing rule: the lens follows the constraint.

Q. Theory of Constraints. What single bottleneck, if elevated, releases the most flow?

A. The in-room clarity-and-conversion rail. He converts once working with someone and is now fully committed, so the one node that gates everything is the first conversation, which leaks at clarity then at the ask. Elevate that and flow begins.

Q. Jobs To Be Done. What job is the buyer hiring this for, and does the offer speak to it?

A. "Find and fix the margin I am losing to broken operations." The documented positioning nails it. The problem is not the words on paper, it is that he never says them the same way twice in person. The locked offer fixes that.

Q. Lean. Where is the waste?

A. Re-improvising the message, in pixels (four website re-skins) and in person (a fresh ramble every conversation). Maximum motion, no locked output. Lock the message once and the waste stops.

Q. Cynefin. Is this complicated or complex?

A. Obvious-domain. The fix is known and mechanical: a locked offer, a memorized pitch, a 3-step ask, drilled. Not knowing what to do was never the problem.

Q. Behavioral Economics. What pattern is driving the behavior?

A. Working-memory overload from an improv-prone, connection-seeing mind. Given an open question with no rail, the connections fire in every direction and he loses the thread. In his words: "My ADHD is hurting them and me." This is a structure problem, not a discipline or courage problem.

Q. Systems Thinking. What rail is missing?

A. The conversational rail. He already built an external rail for his work (an AI operating system he runs his business on) precisely so he would not have to hold it all in his head. He never built the same rail for the sales conversation. Copy his own solution into the one place he never applied it.

Q. Design Thinking. Has he watched himself talk to the user?

A. Now, yes, honestly. He named the failure himself: ~70% leave unclear, ~30% are never asked. That self-observation is what made the real constraint visible. The product was being explained, never landed.

Q. AI Strategy. Is the unique AI advantage being used as proof?

A. Not yet, but it is the fix. He runs his own business on autonomous agents, the most credible demo in his market. Packaged as the in-room live demo (Step 2 of the rail), it is proof, consultative close, and ADHD anchor in one move.

D The Owner Answers (v1 hypotheses replaced)

In v1 these were flagged owner-input-needed, with a best hypothesis each. The owner has now answered. His actual positions replace the hypotheses below, shown in green.

Q. Commitment. Is Catalyst Works the primary business, or a side project?

OWNER ANSWERED

A. All in. It is his primary, full-time job. He job-searched February to May 2026, got no traction, and decided to burn the boats and go all in. Unlimited hours. (v1 hypothesis was "ambivalent / side project in practice." Corrected: the commitment is made.)

Q. Goal. What does success look like, in a number?

OWNER ANSWERED

A. Floor \$12k per month (~\$3k per week) within 2 to 3 months; comfortable at \$15k+; "true success" at \$100 per hour (\$4k per week); long vision \$10k per day. MRR path: cash now, then \$5k MRR, then **\$12 to 16k MRR minimum by end of 2026.**

Q. Delivery model. What is the end-goal engagement shape?

OWNER ANSWERED

A. Fractional operator on retainer (end goal) > advisory-only > done-for-you builds (advisory and DFY close together). He wants to always keep his hands in builds to stay current on the tech, and to hire out builds to a team over time. Considering a roughly two-month program to accelerate build expertise (flagged as a mild focus trade-off).

Q. Distribution reality. Where does he actually find and convert buyers?

OWNER ANSWERED

A. In person, but he is not in the rooms. Not in BNI, Chamber, or owner rooms. Four months of trying to find the buyer online failed. He converts far better in person: "when they work with me things go really well; I just never got a chance to show people what I can do." Plan: rooms, podcasts, and conferences, as participant and presenter. Willing to travel. (v1 risk-tolerance hypothesis, "low appetite for rejection selling," is corrected: the issue is not appetite, it is the missing rail.)

Q. The self-selling gap. Why has converting failed?

OWNER ANSWERED

A. In person, ~70% walk away NOT knowing what he does (rambling); ~30% get it but he does not make the ask. His words: "My ADHD is hurting them and me." The ask-failure is downstream of the clarity-failure. (Full 5-whys in Section E.)

Q. Sales identity. Is the style the problem?

OWNER ANSWERED

A. No. Consultative, never pushy, on purpose: "I prefer to walk people through... they sell themselves and close themselves." This is an asset to preserve. The fix is an external rail (one locked offer + a 3-step consultative ask + his own referral fallback, "if not you, who do you know?"), not "be pushier."

Q. Proof. What credibility does he have without client logos?

OWNER ANSWERED

A. No client logos yet. Operator-as-proof: he runs his own business on a self-built agent system (each subsystem = real problem, the tool he built, the result); this report as a demonstrable deliverable; a live in-room diagnostic on the prospect's own business; and 15 years of Fortune-100 HR context. Honest frame: "here is a real problem, here is the tool I built, here is the result."

Q. Budget. Can he fund ads and travel, and under what rule?

OWNER ANSWERED

A. Yes, but strictly ROI-gated, not limitless and not miserly. Each conference trip must produce booked revenue well above its cost; July workshop ads designed to break even or take a small loss; if July breaks even and yields higher-paying August customers, he will spend more. "You have to spend money to make money," but every dollar needs a return. (Full ROI rules and benchmarks in the main report, Section 10.)

WHAT THE ANSWERS DO TO THE DIAGNOSIS

Three of these answers are load-bearing. Commitment closes the v1 root. The self-selling gap names the v2 root. The sales identity tells us the fix is a rail, not a personality transplant. The rest (goal, delivery rank, distribution, proof, budget) turn the fix from a direction into a costed, sequenced plan.

E The 5-Whys Chain (owner-confirmed, to the real root)

v1 drove this chain to "an unmade commitment." The owner's answers reroute it: commitment is made, so the chain continues past it to the structural root, confirmed in his own words.

THE CHAIN, DRIVEN TO THE OWNER-CONFIRMED ROOT

Why is revenue zero?

Because almost no one he meets becomes a client.

Why does almost no one convert?

Because he gets in front of people but loses the room. ~70% leave not knowing what he does; the ~30% who get it are never asked.

Why do they leave not knowing what he does?

Because he has no locked, simple offer, so he improvises the explanation every time.

Why does improvising fail?

Because his mind sees connections across domains and fires in every direction. Unanchored, the improv spirals into tangents and he loses his own thread. "My ADHD is hurting them and me."

Why does he never reach the ask?

Because the ask lives at the end of a clear thread, and he never reaches clarity, so he defaults to "let's talk more."

Why has this never been fixed?

Because he has been trying to fix it with discipline (try to be clearer, remember to ask) instead of structure. Willpower cannot do a rail's job.

Root: an improv-prone, connection-seeing mind running the most important conversation in the business with no external rail. The ask-failure is downstream of the clarity-failure, and the clarity-failure is downstream of the missing rail.

THE COMMITMENT CHAIN (V1'S ROOT, NOW CLOSED)

Was the in-person motion never run because attention was divided?

That was the v1 read. The owner corrects it: he is now all in, full-time, boats burned.

So does fixing commitment fix the revenue?

No, and that is the key finding. He is committed and still converts zero, because commitment was never the binding constraint, the rail was. Removing the commitment question exposed the real wound.

Resolution: v1's "unmade commitment" is closed by the owner's answer. The chain does not stop there; it continues to the missing rail, which is where it always actually ended.

THE NON-OBVIOUS BRIDGE (HIS SUPERPOWER, TURNED INWARD)

The trait that makes him a great diagnostic consultant, cross-domain connection-spotting, is the same trait that loses him the room. Pointed at a client's problem (the problem is the rail), it is a gift. Pointed at an open "so what do you do" with no rail, it is a tangent machine. The fix is not to dull the gift, it is to give every important conversation a rail so the connection-engine runs on a track. He already proved he can do this: he built an AI operating system to externalize the structure his work needs. The rail is that same move, applied to his mouth.

F The Council Reruns & Premortems (against the new fact)

Five independent voices, re-run in premortem mode against the fact that commitment is made. Five rounds, written as challenge and response. The job: re-rank the constraint and premortem the new fix.

Round 1 -- the new fact enters: commitment is made

The Contrarian

Challenge: the precondition is gone. So what?

Removing the excuse exposes the wound. He is all in and still converts zero, because the moment he is in front of a buyer he loses them. Commitment was never going to fix a mouth with no rail. v1 was hiding the real problem behind a decision that was already being made.

First Principles

Challenge: which v1 assumption just broke?

"The in-person motion converts if you run it." It does not. He has been in front of people and 70 percent leave not knowing what he does. There is a hidden node between "in the room" and "closed," and it is clarity.

The Outsider

Challenge: what does an outsider see now?

A prospect who cannot say what he does cannot buy and cannot refer. The second part is the killer: zero clarity equals zero word of mouth, so distribution can never compound. Every confused conversation is a dead end, not a seed.

The Expansionist

Challenge: what is the instinct to resist?

"Get in more rooms now that he is committed." Wrong order. Pour rooms into a broken rail and you burn rooms. Build the rail first, then the same rooms start producing. The rail is the multiplier; rooms are the volume.

The Executor

Challenge: name the always-visible pattern.

Four website re-skins is the same ramble in pixels. He cannot hold one message in his mouth or on the page. The fix was always "lock one sentence and make it un-improvisable." True in March, true now.

Round 2 -- re-rank the constraint

Convergence

With commitment demoted to resolved, two candidates remain: distribution (not in the rooms) and conversion (loses the rooms). Conversion is binding first, because rooms are relatively cheap to enter but every room is wasted, and the referral layer poisoned, if the conversation has no rail. Distribution is binding second. The convenient answers stay dead: not the ads, not the price, not "no strategy," and now also not "he is not committed."

Round 3 -- the owner-confirmed root

The 5-Whys, confirmed

No locked offer leads to improvising, improvising spirals because of how his mind connects, the spiral loses the thread, the lost thread never reaches the ask. The voices agree on the distinction that matters: this is a structure problem, not a discipline problem. "Be clearer and remember to ask" has failed for months because it asks willpower to do a rail's job.

Round 4 -- premortem the new fix (the rail)

Premortem A

"We built the rail and he still rambled." Why?

He never drilled it, or abandoned it mid-conversation when a connection sparked. Mitigation: drill out loud daily to automatic; keep it to three steps; make the live demo (Step 2) the physical anchor he returns to when the spiral starts.

Premortem B

"The rail killed the warmth that closes." Why?

Over-scripting suppressed the consultative style that wins. Mitigation: the rail is a skeleton, not a script-read. Lock the opening, the middle move, and the close. Free to be consultative between the rungs. Rails on the turns, freedom on the straights.

Premortem C

"Rail fixed, but he never got in enough rooms." Why?

ROI-gated travel got read as "stay home." Mitigation: local rooms are free, podcasts are remote and free; only conferences cost money and those are ROI-gated. No budget excuse to be roomless.

Premortem D

The v1 precondition, re-tested: "He took a job after all." Why?

This no longer fires. He job-searched Feb to May, got no traction, burned the boats. The v1 binding precondition is closed and recorded as closed, not carried as a live risk.

CHAIRMAN SYNTHESIS -- CONVERGENCE ~93%

With commitment resolved, the binding constraint is the in-room clarity-and-conversion rail: the missing external structure (one locked offer, a memorized pitch, a three-step consultative ask) that lets his connection-seeing mind sell instead of wander. Distribution is the necessary second move, gated behind the rail. The fix is a built artifact, drilled to automatic, with the live demo as its anchor and his consultative style preserved between the rungs. Every convenient answer, including v1's own "unmade commitment," is retired with evidence.

WHERE THIS LANDS (V2)

The verdict moved, because the owner answered the one question only he could. The commitment is made. The market is real and the pricing is right. The single thing between here and revenue is a rail, one locked message said the same way every time, so the most important conversation in the business stops rambling. Read the [Margin Diagnostic Sprint report \(v2\)](#), for the rail itself, the proof inventory, the distribution plan, and the 30/60/90.

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Method: documented discovery-call protocol + four-level maturity scoring + 8-lens diagnostic + an owner-confirmed 5-Whys chain + a five-round Sankofa Council in premortem mode. v1 owner-input hypotheses replaced with the owner's live answers.